

A Fish Called Neta

It's bad enough that the political class in India has let us down consistently. Now they are beginning to pollute the pristine purity of India's ecology with their liberal and at times unnecessary analogies with the far more beautiful fauna and flora that inhabit the wild. Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi kicked off the season of politico-ecological abuse when, in an overt reference to Congress MP Rahul Gandhi, he said in a recent speech, "We are not small fish floating around in the comfort of aquariums but we weather huge storms to win." Then at another function he said, "Flowers grown in an orchard may be beautiful but flowers growing on their own in the jungle have their own power and different fragrance. Friends, I am a flower grown in a jungle."

The retorts from the Congress came fast and furious. "If Rahul is like a fish in the aquarium," Congress spokesman Manish Tiwari said in Delhi, "then Modi is a piranha who devoured human beings." In Gujarat, state Congress spokesperson Arjun Modhavadia said, "Rahul prefers to be among common people while this wild flower, who wears designer clothes and watches, wants to live in the company of the rich and the famous." Abhishek Singhvi rubbed it in further by saying, "Modi's statement shows that he believes in *matsya nyaya* (jungle law) where the powerful swallow the weaker."

While green consciousness of any kind among netas is welcome, it would be interesting to see how many of them are truly aware of the range of ecological problems that beset the country. Whether it is climate change, vanishing tigers, diminishing forest cover, pollution of our rivers and lakes, not to mention our metros, all these are problems crying for urgent attention and reme-

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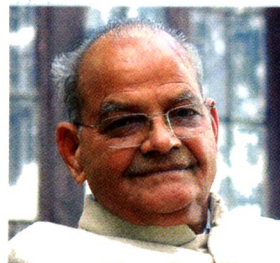
dies. Yet our political debate is rarely dominated by such issues and instead the focus remains strongly on personalities. While personalities do drive elections as they did in the recent US polls, equally important was their stand on major issues and what they were planning to do about them.

With the Indian general elections around the corner, as citizens it's time we focussed on our netas' approach to the burning issues and assessed their capability to handle them. For those politicians who think they are clever by indulging in eco-insults, there is a memorable line from Wanda, the principal figure in the film *A Fish Called Wanda*, "To call you stupid would be an insult to stupid people! I've known sheep that could outwit you. I've worn dresses with higher IQs. But you think you're an intellectual, don't you, ape?"



SIGNPOSTS

SENTENCED: By a Delhi court, former communications minister **Sabhiram** to three years' imprisonment in a disproportionate



assets case. He was charged by the CBI in 1996 for amassing wealth amounting to Rs 4.25 crore during the Narasimha Rao government between 1991 and 1996.

DIED: Broadcaster and film critic **Amita Malik**, 87, known as "first lady of Indian media", for her comprehensive and incisive interviews of celebrities and columns. She began her career with All India Radio.

ORDAINED: Dr **Franco Mulakkal**, 45, as the Auxiliary Bishop of the Catholic Archdiocese of Delhi.

APPOINTED: **Sabbir Hussain Sheikh Adam Khandawala**, as the Gujarat director-general of police. He is a 1973 batch IPS officer and replaces DGP P.C. Pandey.

